What Happens in a Pre-Shipment Inspection? A Buyer's Checklist

By Safe-T TECH International, Sialkot, Pakistan · Published 30 October 2026

When you order garments from a factory overseas, the most expensive moment of the whole process is the one you never see: the day your goods are packed and shipped. A **pre-shipment inspection** exists to put a trained pair of eyes on that moment. An independent inspector visits the factory when your order is complete and packed, checks it against your approved sample and specification, and sends you a photo-documented report before you release payment or authorise shipment. This guide explains exactly what that visit covers, what it does not cover, and the checklist smart buyers use before they say "ship it".



When a pre-shipment inspection happens — and why timing matters

A pre-shipment inspection, also called a final random inspection (PSI/FRI), takes place when production is finished and at least the bulk of the order is packed and ready. That timing is deliberate: it is the last point at which problems can still be fixed without the cost and embarrassment of a return shipment. Inspect too early and there is nothing finished to check; inspect after dispatch and the report is only a record of what went wrong. Book the visit as soon as the factory confirms a packing date, and make sure the inspector will have access to the finished, packed goods — not just a few display pieces on a table.

The value is simple. You are buying from another country, in another time zone, often from a factory you have never visited. The inspection replaces trust with evidence: counted cartons, measured garments, photographed labels and a written verdict on whether the order matches what you approved. For a buyer placing their first order with a new supplier, that evidence is worth far more than the cost of the visit.

1. Quantity and completeness: is everything there?

The first check is the most basic and the most commonly failed: does the shipment contain what you ordered? The inspector counts cartons and pieces, verifies the count against your purchase order, and checks the size and colour breakdown. A shipment that is short by one size run — say, all the mediums missing from a teamwear order, or a colour dropped from a swimwear range — is a problem you want to find in the factory warehouse, not in your own stockroom. The inspector also checks that cartons are sealed, marked and counted correctly, so the quantity on the packing list matches the quantity on the floor.

2. Workmanship: how well is it made?

Next, the inspector opens cartons at random — never only the top carton the factory offers — and examines garments piece by piece. This is the workmanship check: stitching quality, seam strength, loose threads, uneven hems, fabric defects, stains, print or embroidery quality, and zips, buttons and trims that work as they should. Defects are recorded by type and severity, with photographs, so you can see for yourself whether a flaw is a one-off or a pattern across the production run. A good report distinguishes clearly between minor issues you might accept and major defects that should block shipment.

3. Measurements: does it match the specification?

A garment can look perfect and still be wrong if the measurements are off. The inspector measures sample pieces against your specification sheet and your approved sample — chest width, body length, sleeve length and any other key measurement for that product. Tolerances are agreed in advance, so the verdict is objective rather than a matter of opinion. This check matters most for fitted products: team kits that must match a size run, uniforms worn by staff all day, and swimwear and lingerie where a centimetre changes the fit. If measurements drift across the production run, the report shows it, size by size.

4. Matching the approved sample: is this what you approved?

Every inspection is judged against one reference: the sample you approved. The inspector compares the production pieces with that sample for fabric, colour, construction, print placement, branding and overall finish. Colour is a frequent source of disputes, so the comparison is done in good light and photographed — a shade that looks close under factory lighting can read very differently in daylight. If the factory substituted a fabric or changed a construction detail without telling you, this is the check that catches it. Keep your approved sample safe and clearly labelled; it is the single most important document in the whole inspection.

5. Labelling, tags and packing: the details buyers forget

Labelling errors are small, cheap to fix at the factory and expensive to fix after delivery. The inspector checks brand labels, size tags, care labels and any "Made in" tag against your instructions — including a "Made in [your country]" tag where you requested one. Packing is checked the same way: the right pieces folded and bagged as specified, the right assortment per carton, hang tags and packaging as agreed, and cartons marked with the correct style, size and quantity. A shipment that arrives with the wrong labels is a shipment you cannot sell as your own brand, however good the garments inside are.

The buyer's pre-shipment checklist

Before you authorise any shipment, run through this checklist with your inspector's report in hand:

- Quantity: does the counted total match your purchase order, by style, size and colour?
- Workmanship: are defects isolated, or do they repeat across the inspected pieces?

- Measurements: do the measured pieces fall within the agreed tolerances of your spec?
- Sample match: do fabric, colour, print and construction match the approved sample?
- Labels and tags: are brand labels, size tags and care labels correct and complete?
- Packing: is the carton assortment, marking and packaging as you specified?
- Photos: does the report show the actual goods, not just the best pieces?
- Verdict: is the inspector's recommendation clear — accept, reject, or fix and re-check?

If any answer is unclear, ask for more photographs or a re-check of that point before you release payment. A factory that is confident in its goods will welcome a second look; a factory that resists one is telling you something.

What a pre-shipment inspection does not cover

An inspection is a powerful tool, but it is not magic, and honest inspectors will say so. It checks the finished goods against your sample and specification — it cannot verify what happened inside the factory weeks earlier, it cannot test every single piece in a large order, and it cannot catch problems your specification never mentioned. That is why the other inspection types exist: an Initial Production Inspection (IPI) checks raw materials and first output at the start of production, a During Production Inspection (DUPRO) catches problems mid-run while they can still be corrected, Container Loading Supervision watches the goods being loaded, and a Factory Audit assesses the factory itself before you place an order. Used together, the five types form a complete programme; used alone, a pre-shipment inspection is still the single most valuable visit for most buyers, because it guards the moment money and goods change hands.

How to prepare for an inspection

Good preparation makes a good report. Send your inspector the purchase order, the specification sheet, the approved sample (or detailed photographs of it), and your packing and labelling instructions before the visit. Agree the acceptance criteria in advance — which defects are critical, which are minor, and what outcome you want if the goods fail. Tell the factory the inspection is coming; a professional supplier expects it, and a surprise visit helps nobody. Finally, read the report the day it arrives. An inspection report sitting unread in an inbox protects nothing — the decisions it informs should be made while the goods are still at the factory, where fixing them is cheapest.

Your next step

If you place orders with factories in Pakistan and want an independent check before you pay or ship, our surveyors cover the whole country. We visit the factory, check your order against your approved sample, photograph the goods and send you a written inspection report — for pre-shipment inspection, during-production checks, container loading supervision and factory audits alike. Tell us about your order on WhatsApp at +92-339-5099397 or by email at contact.safettech@gmail.com, or use our contact page — and read more about the service on our inspection services page.



I have seen buyers lose money not because the factory was dishonest, but because nobody checked the goods before they left. If you are ordering from Pakistan, let us be your eyes at the factory — I would rather give you an honest report than a comfortable one.

Ahmed Zahid

Founder & Director, Safe-T TECH International · Sialkot, Pakistan

Ordering from Pakistan? Get it checked first.

An independent inspection report before you release payment — covering quantity, workmanship, measurements, labelling and packing.

Chat on WhatsApp Get a Quote